

Guide 36 — Warehouse and Inventory Control Specialist

Controlled English working master — version 2.0

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What this job is

Warehouse and inventory-control work helps organizations receive, store, track, move, count, document, and release materials or products accurately. Employers use many titles for this family of work, including inventory clerk, inventory control specialist, warehouse inventory clerk, receiving clerk, shipping clerk, materials control associate, stock-control clerk, warehouse coordinator, receiving coordinator, shipping coordinator, and related roles.

This guide uses **Warehouse and Inventory Control Specialist** as an umbrella career title. It does not mean every employer uses the same job description or that one occupational code covers every warehouse or inventory-control position.

In the United States, a close official reference occupation is O*NET 43-5071.00, **Shipping, Receiving, and Inventory Clerks**. In Canada, **Inventory control clerk** is mapped by Job Bank to **Purchasing and inventory control workers, NOC 14403**. Local titles, duties, physical demands, software, wages, and training expectations vary by employer and country.

This guide is for career exploration and preparation. Verify current local requirements before paying for training or accepting a job offer.

What you may do

Typical responsibilities can include:

- receive materials, supplies, parts, merchandise, or equipment;
- compare shipments with purchase orders, manifests, invoices, packing lists, or other records;
- record quantities, locations, lot numbers, serial numbers, dates, damages, shortages, or discrepancies;
- put goods into the correct storage location using the employer's inventory procedures;
- prepare items and documents for shipping, transfer, issue, or return;
- update inventory records in spreadsheets, inventory systems, ERP systems, warehouse-management systems, scanners, or other approved tools;
- perform cycle counts, spot checks, or scheduled physical inventories;
- investigate and document differences between physical stock and system records;
- communicate with warehouse, purchasing, production, logistics, carriers, suppliers, customers, or supervisors;
- help maintain labeling, location, barcode, or RFID accuracy where those systems are used;
- report damaged, missing, unsafe, expired, quarantined, or nonconforming material; and

- follow employer rules for safety, security, quality, privacy, and access control.

Some jobs are mostly clerical and system-based. Others involve frequent physical movement, loading areas, storage racks, packing, palletized goods, or production support. Advanced inventory-control roles may include deeper analysis, replenishment planning, root-cause review, ERP/WMS reporting, or process improvement.

Work environment

Warehouse and inventory roles can be found in manufacturing, retail, wholesale distribution, healthcare, construction supply, government, transportation, food and beverage, electronics, automotive, pharmaceuticals, e-commerce, and many other sectors.

Possible conditions include:

- standing and walking;
- bending, reaching, lifting, carrying, or moving materials within employer-defined limits;
- noise;
- loading docks and vehicle traffic;
- hot, cold, refrigerated, or non-climate-controlled areas;
- time pressure and shipping deadlines;
- repetitive scanning or data entry;
- personal protective equipment in designated areas; and
- powered equipment operated only by trained and authorized workers.

Never operate a forklift, powered industrial truck, conveyor, dock device, lift, or other machinery without the training and authorization required by the employer and local rules. Never bypass machine-safety, lockout/tagout, hazardous-material, food-safety, pharmaceutical, quality, security, or PPE controls to move work faster.

Skills that matter

Employers commonly value:

- accuracy and attention to detail;
- basic arithmetic and comfort with quantities, units, dates, and counts;
- spreadsheet basics;
- barcode or scanner familiarity;
- inventory, ERP, or WMS literacy;
- recordkeeping and document control;
- receiving and shipping basics;
- cycle counting and discrepancy follow-up;
- organization and location discipline;
- clear written and verbal communication;
- safe material handling;

- ability to identify missing or inconsistent information;
- calm problem solving when stock records do not match physical inventory; and
- professional communication across departments and with suppliers, carriers, or customers.

A specific software product is not universally required. O*NET currently identifies inventory-management software, warehouse-management systems, ERP products, spreadsheets, barcode-labeling software, RFID/scanning tools, and related systems in this occupation family. Learn the concepts first, then build familiarity with the systems used by the employers you are targeting.

Education and entry pathways

United States

ONET places *Shipping, Receiving, and Inventory Clerks* in **Job Zone 1-2: Very Little to Some Preparation Needed**. Current ONET information says that occupations in this zone usually require a high school diploma or GED, though some may not, and job training can range from a few days to one year.

A practical entry path can be:

1. Build basic spreadsheet, inventory, receiving, shipping, and workplace-communication skills.
2. Learn the concepts behind item numbers, quantities, storage locations, cycle counts, discrepancies, purchase orders, shipments, and inventory status.
3. Practice with a simple spreadsheet inventory log or a training sandbox if one is available.
4. Apply for inventory clerk, receiving clerk, shipping clerk, warehouse associate with inventory duties, materials-control, or stock-control roles.
5. Use paid onboarding and cross-training to learn the employer's actual system, safety rules, scanning process, and documentation standards.
6. Progress toward inventory-control specialist, warehouse coordinator, inventory analyst, materials coordinator, planner, or supervisory roles as experience grows.

Canada

Government of Canada Job Bank maps **Inventory control clerk** to **Purchasing and inventory control workers, NOC 14403**. Current national requirements say that secondary school completion is usually required. Courses in production and inventory management and the ability to operate a computerized inventory system may be required for inventory-control workers.

Job Bank's current record does not identify this occupation as regulated nationally. Employers may still require safety training, equipment authorization, language ability, software skills, or sector-specific experience.

Colombia

SENA currently lists several relevant logistics and inventory programs through Betowa. Examples include:

- **Administración y Control de Inventarios** — complementary virtual training, 40 hours in the currently surfaced listing;
- **Integración de Operaciones Logísticas** — technical training covering logistics information, storage, receiving, and dispatch;
- **Gestión Logística** — technologist training covering acquisition, movement, storage, and inventory control;
- **Control de Inventarios con Herramientas Digitales** — complementary training where offered;
- **Valoración de Inventarios** — complementary training where offered; and
- **Almacenamiento, Movilización y Alistamiento de Mercancías** — complementary training where offered.

Some current Betowa listings are company-specific, location-specific, or offered only during limited enrollment periods. Verify the live offer before planning around a particular course.

Colombian job seekers can also use the Ministry of Labour's **Sistema Nacional de Cualificaciones** to explore qualification pathways and recognition of prior learning, and **OCUPACOL** to explore occupational profiles and related titles.

Useful Colombian search terms can include *auxiliar de inventarios*, *control de inventarios*, *almacenista*, *auxiliar de almacén*, *auxiliar logístico*, *recibo y despacho*, *coordinador de inventarios*, *control de existencias*, *centro de distribución*, and *operaciones logísticas*.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Training and qualification systems vary by country. OIT/Cinterfor can help learners identify national vocational-training and competency systems across the region. Examples include SENA in Colombia, SENCE in Chile, INTECAP in Guatemala, INFOTEP in the Dominican Republic, and INEFOP in Uruguay.

Verify the current program, cost, eligibility, recognition, practical component, and employer relevance in your own country before paying for private training.

Free-first learning strategy

Do not assume you need an expensive private warehouse or inventory certificate before applying. A safer sequence is:

1. Read current job postings in your area and list the recurring requirements.
2. Use public, employer-provided, or low-cost training first.
3. Build spreadsheet, inventory, receiving, shipping, barcode/scanner, ERP/WMS, and safety awareness.
4. Ask employers about paid onboarding, cross-training, equipment training, tuition assistance, reimbursement, trainee programs, or internal promotion.

5. Consider paid training only after verifying the total cost, refund rules, employer recognition, and whether the credential appears in real job postings.

For entry-level work, transferable experience in retail stockrooms, warehouses, shipping/receiving, purchasing support, logistics, production, maintenance stores, healthcare supplies, administration, or customer order support can be valuable.

Apprenticeship and work-based learning

In the United States, O*NET links this occupation family to Apprenticeship.gov as a source for related apprenticeship opportunities. Registered Apprenticeships are employer-driven programs that can combine paid work, structured learning, mentorship, progressive wage increases, and an industry-recognized credential.

Use Apprenticeship.gov to search current opportunities. The presence of an occupation or apprenticeship category does not mean a current opening exists in your city or state.

Elsewhere, look for:

- paid trainee roles;
- employer apprenticeships;
- internships or work-study programs;
- dual-training models;
- public technical programs with practical stages;
- employer cross-training; and
- internal promotion from warehouse, receiving, shipping, or stockroom roles.

Funding, scholarships, and employer support

United States

CareerOneStop provides a **WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder**. If you are eligible for Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act training services, an American Job Center can help you identify approved providers and local options.

WIOA support is not automatic. Eligibility, available funding, covered programs, and local rules vary.

Canada

Eligible post-secondary learners may qualify for **Canada Student Grants and Loans** through federal, provincial, or territorial systems. Grants generally do not need to be repaid; loans do.

Starting August 1, 2026, Canada changed federal student-aid eligibility for private, for-profit international schools, with transition rules for some continuing students. Additional changes for certain private, for-profit schools in Canada may also affect grant eligibility. Verify current provincial or territorial eligibility before enrolling.

Short private warehouse courses are not automatically eligible for student aid.

Colombia and Latin America

Check public vocational systems before paying private providers. In Colombia, start with SENA and the national qualifications system. Elsewhere in Latin America, use OIT/Cinterfor to locate the relevant public vocational institution and then verify current enrollment and funding rules on that institution's official site.

Employer support

Ask about:

- paid onboarding;
- safety training;
- scanner, ERP, WMS, or inventory-system training;
- cross-training in receiving, shipping, purchasing, production, or logistics;
- forklift or other equipment training when the role requires it and the employer provides or recognizes appropriate training;
- tuition assistance;
- certification reimbursement;
- apprenticeships or trainee programs; and
- internal promotion pathways.

Get reimbursement conditions in writing before spending money. Some programs require continued employment or repayment if you leave within a specified period.

Income and job outlook

United States — official occupational data

O*NET currently reports Bureau of Labor Statistics data for **Shipping, Receiving, and Inventory Clerks**:

- **Median hourly wage (2025): \$21.76**
- **Median annual wage (2025): \$45,260**
- **Employment (2024): 862,200**
- **Projected growth, 2024-2034: decline (-1% or lower)**
- **Projected annual openings, 2024-2034: 69,300**

These are national occupational statistics. They are not a promised starting wage and can differ substantially by location, industry, shift, physical demands, experience, union status, employer, and responsibility level.

United States — current non-government estimates

Private salary sites use broader or different titles and samples than BLS/O*NET.

As of July 2026:

- Indeed reported an average base salary of about **\$21.08 per hour** for *Inventory Control Specialist*, updated July 20, 2026.
- Indeed reported about **\$19.96 per hour** for *Inventory Specialist*, updated July 26, 2026.
- Salary.com reported an average of about 47,371 *per year* *for Inventory Control Specialist as of July 1, 2026, with a stated range of* **\$42,789-\$53,549**.

These are **non-government market estimates**, not official occupational medians and not guaranteed earnings.

Canada — official national data

Government of Canada Job Bank currently reports the following national wages for **Inventory control clerk / NOC 14403**:

- low: **CAD \$17.50 per hour**
- median: **CAD \$24.00 per hour**
- high: **CAD \$36.06 per hour**

The wage table was updated November 19, 2025 using 2023-2024 Labour Force Survey data and remains the current national Job Bank record in 2026. Local wages and prospects vary by province and region.

A practical 10-week starter plan

Weeks 1-2: Read 15-20 current job postings in your target area. Record common titles, shifts, physical requirements, software, equipment, education, and experience requirements.

Weeks 3-4: Strengthen spreadsheet and recordkeeping skills. Practice item numbers, descriptions, quantities, units, locations, dates, and simple discrepancy logs.

Weeks 5-6: Learn inventory concepts: receiving, put-away, storage locations, cycle counts, physical inventory, reorder points at a conceptual level, damaged goods, quarantine/status controls, FIFO/FEFO where relevant, purchase orders, shipping documents, and basic warehouse flow.

Weeks 7-8: Build a small practice exercise. Create a simple inventory table, receive a sample shipment, record a shortage, move stock to locations, perform a cycle count, document a discrepancy, and prepare a short professional variance report.

Weeks 9-10: Verify public training, employer support, funding, trainee or apprenticeship options, reimbursement rules, and the actual requirements of the jobs you plan to pursue. Update your resume using truthful examples of accuracy, inventory, stock handling, shipping, receiving, logistics, purchasing support, data entry, quality control, or problem solving.

Building experience without already having the title

Transferable experience can come from:

- retail stockrooms;

- shipping and receiving;
- warehouse operations;
- purchasing or procurement support;
- manufacturing or production support;
- logistics;
- maintenance parts rooms;
- healthcare supply rooms;
- food-service inventory;
- e-commerce fulfillment;
- office supply or asset control; and
- customer-service work involving orders, deliveries, returns, or shortages.

When describing experience, show what you actually did. Useful evidence includes:

- keeping counts accurate;
- documenting discrepancies;
- reducing data-entry errors;
- organizing storage locations;
- tracking orders or shipments;
- resolving shortages;
- improving handoffs;
- maintaining current records;
- following safety and quality rules; and
- communicating clearly when stock or documentation did not match.

Do not claim ERP, WMS, forklift, hazardous-material, or advanced inventory-analysis expertise if you have only studied the concepts.

Advancement

Possible next steps include:

- senior inventory clerk;
- inventory control specialist;
- warehouse coordinator;
- receiving or shipping coordinator;
- materials coordinator;
- inventory analyst;
- cycle-count lead;
- stockroom lead;
- logistics coordinator;
- warehouse supervisor;
- materials planner; or
- supply-chain support roles.

Advanced positions may require stronger ERP/WMS knowledge, analytics, supervisory experience, sector-specific compliance knowledge, formal supply-chain education, or deeper production and materials-planning experience.

Before paying for a degree or certificate, compare several current job postings for the exact role you want and determine whether the credential is actually requested.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI tools may help you:

- draft a neutral inventory-status message;
- create practice interview questions;
- summarize non-sensitive training notes;
- explain general inventory concepts;
- create sample spreadsheet exercises using fictional data; or
- brainstorm questions to ask during onboarding.

AI should not replace the employer's inventory system, approved calculations, count procedures, quality controls, security procedures, or human judgment.

Do not paste confidential inventory levels, customer orders, supplier pricing, facility layouts, proprietary part numbers, shipment schedules, employee data, credentials, security details, access codes, regulated information, or other protected business information into a public AI service unless your employer has explicitly approved that use and the data handling is authorized.

Verify AI-generated quantities, formulas, stock recommendations, reorder calculations, dates, routing suggestions, classifications, and citations before operational use. A plausible-looking error can create shortages, overstock, shipment delays, financial loss, compliance problems, or safety risks.

Cybersecurity and privacy basics

Warehouse and inventory systems can contain commercially sensitive and security-relevant information. Follow your employer's rules for:

- account access and multifactor authentication;
- password and credential handling;
- phishing and suspicious attachments;
- approved scanners and mobile devices;
- file sharing;
- removable media;
- supplier and customer information;
- inventory levels and shipment schedules;
- facility and storage-location information;
- incident reporting; and

- use of personal devices or external AI tools.

If you receive an unusual request to change a delivery address, supplier bank account, shipment destination, inventory write-off, purchase instruction, or system access, verify it through the employer's approved process before acting.

Avoid scams and weak training offers

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, or training seller:

- guarantees a job or a specific salary;
- pressures you to pay immediately;
- claims one private certificate is legally required when official sources do not support that claim;
- will not disclose total cost, refund rules, or financing terms;
- cannot explain which employers recognize the credential;
- asks you to pay for a job offer, equipment shipment, or background check through gift cards, cryptocurrency, or an unusual payment method; or
- asks for sensitive identity or banking information before you have independently verified the organization.

Verify employers and training providers independently and use official websites whenever possible.

When to pause before spending money

Pause or delay enrollment when:

- local job postings do not require the credential you are considering;
- the provider will not give total costs and refund terms in writing;
- public or employer-paid training may cover the same skill;
- you have not confirmed whether employers in your area recognize the program;
- the schedule, shift pattern, physical demands, or commute do not fit your circumstances;
- the course promises equipment authorization without a credible employer or regulatory context; or
- financing terms create debt you cannot comfortably repay.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- U.S. Department of Labor O*NET OnLine — Shipping, Receiving, and Inventory Clerks: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/43-5071.00>
- Apprenticeship.gov: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/>
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/EmploymentAndTraining/find-WIOA-training-programs.aspx>

- Government of Canada Job Bank — Inventory Control Clerk requirements: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/15270/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Inventory Control Clerk wages: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/wages-occupation/15270/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Inventory Control Clerk summary: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/summary-occupation/15270/ca>
- Canada Student Grants and Loans: <https://www.canada.ca/en/services/benefits/education/student-aid/grants-loans.html>
- SENA Betowa — Administración y Control de Inventarios: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/administracion-y-control-de-inventarios?offertype=company&programId=6634>
- SENA Betowa — Integración de Operaciones Logísticas: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/integracion-de-operaciones-logisticas>
- SENA Betowa — Gestión Logística: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/gestion-logistica?modality=P>
- SENA Betowa — Control de Inventarios con Herramientas Digitales: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/control-de-inventarios-con-herramientas-digitales?modality=P&offertype=company&programId=113894>
- SENA Betowa — Valoración de Inventarios: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/valoracion-de-inventarios?programId=158494>
- SENA Betowa — Almacenamiento, Movilización y Alistamiento de Mercancías: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/almacenamiento-movilizacion-y-alistamiento-de-mercancias?offertype=company&programId=172615>
- Colombia Ministerio del Trabajo — Sistema Nacional de Cualificaciones: <https://cualificaciones.mintrabajo.gov.co/>
- Colombia Ministerio del Trabajo — OCUPACOL: <https://ocupacol.mintrabajo.gov.co/>
- OIT/Cinterfor: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/>

Supplementary non-government salary sources:

- Indeed — Inventory Control Specialist salaries: <https://www.indeed.com/career/inventory-control-specialist/salaries>
- Indeed — Inventory Specialist salaries: <https://www.indeed.com/career/inventory-specialist/salaries>
- Salary.com — Inventory Control Specialist salary: <https://www.salary.com/research/salary/listing/inventory-control-specialist-salary>

Source and review note

This guide uses current-source research recorded on August 12, 2026. Wages, course availability, funding rules, job requirements, software expectations, and local hiring conditions can change. Recheck official sources and current job postings before acting.

This controlled revision was produced with AI assistance and auditable source review. It does **not** claim independent human certification, professional accreditation, certified translation, legal review, financial advice, or guaranteed employment outcomes.